COVER STORY

HOW INDIA MOVES

TWO LANDMARK NATIONAL SURVEYS REVEAL THE CHANGING WAYS INDIANS TRAVEL FOR WORK, HEALTH AND LEISURE, AND EXPOSE THE SHORTCOMINGS IN OUR TRANSPORT AND TOURISM INFRASTRUCTURE



Our country has witnessed many dramatic transformations on its long journey of growth and infrastructural development. The acceleration of high-speed train networks, metro systems, the liftoff of private aviation and the expansion of a skein of multi-lane highways are phenomena many of us have witnessed—often with hope but not infrequently with frustration at the disruptions, delays and miscalculations that have accompanied them. While the sense that major change—however stuttering—is afoot has been pervasive, what has been less clear is an analysis of just how this has changed the lives and travel habits of the average Indian commuter or tourist.

Now, thanks to the recent release of two major surveys covering lakhs of citizens across the country, that picture has become much clearer. One of these, the first National Household Travel Survey (NHTS), covering 492,000 households, was released in October. The other, the 2026 Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey (DTES)—covering a sample base of 246,113 households—was released in September. The latter also offered data with some time range, as it built on a previous survey conducted a decade earlier. Together, they offer a wealth of data on India in motion: from preferred modes of travel to the reasons we travel and how much time and money we are willing, or obliged, to spend on the road.

As it turns out, some of the flashier aspects of transportation infrastructure—aviation and metros—are still insignificant in comparison with rubber wheels on tarmac. Perhaps the primary contest that emerges from the surveys is that between private vehicles and buses as India's transport of choice. How our urban and highway planners prioritise infrastructure for each of these categories will clearly be of some consequence. Other startling findings in the surveys reflect the scale and growth of pilgrimage and religious yatras as an engine of parsimonious tourism—characterised by high footfalls with low spend. What emerges, as you will see in the following pages, is a complicated picture reflecting both where we are and where we are headed. It also offers an opportunity to consider the road ahead and decide wherever we need to change lanes. ■

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS/AI**